Léo Denis

CRG-i3, École Polytechnique
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Personal Website

Research Interests

Strategic Management, Sustainability, Organizational Design, Financial Intermediation, Sustainable Finance & Impact Investing

Education

École Polytechnique — Palaiseau, France
Ph.D. in Management Science — 2022–2026

Thesis: "Building the Social Impact of Finance: an Organizational Perspective on Private Equity"

- Committee: Pr. Nicolas Mottis (École Polytechnique), Pr. Caroline Flammer (Columbia University), Pr. Benjamin Lependeven (Audencia)
- Jury: Pr. Rodolphe Durand (HEC Paris), Pr. Jean-Pascal Gond (Bayes Business School), Pr. Diane-Laure Arjaliès (Ivey Business School), Pr. Blanche Segrestin (Mines ParisTech), Pr. Jérôme Caby (IAE Paris)

Columbia University - SIPA. Visiting PhD Student (Pr. Caroline Flammer) — Fall 2024 and 2025-2026

École Normale Supérieure Paris-Saclay — Gif-sur-Yvette, France
Civil Servant – Ranked 1st, National Competitive Entrance Exam (5̃00 candidates) — 2018–2022

- ENS Paris-Saclay's Diploma - Economics & Management Department (2022)
- Master's Degree in Management Research, with Honors (2021)

École Nationale de Commerce — Paris, France
Classe Préparatoire aux Grandes Écoles ENS D2 (Rank: 1st) — 2016–2018
Bachelor's Degree in Mathematics (Years 1 & 2)

Working papers

Hybridizing Investors: Designing Investment Organizations for Social Impact *with Nicolas Mottis*

AOM 2026 Best Papers Proceedings

Abstract: Sustainable investors seek to reconcile financial performance with social impact, yet often struggle to translate this ambition into investment practice. Based on an 18-month ethnography of a climate-transition private equity fund, we show how asset owners and asset managers design investment organizations before market entry. We theorize how early choices regarding objectives, resources, and control structures shape subsequent investment behavior and social impact potential.

Organizational Architectures of Sustainable Investment Funds: Evidence from Private Equity

Draft available

Abstract: I conceptualize sustainable investment funds as hybrid organizations that seek to combine financial and sustainability logics within a single organizational architecture. Drawing on a proprietary, first-hand dataset assembled in collaboration with Bpifrance, the French public investment bank, I analyze 89 French private equity funds raised between 2017 and 2026 and use configurational clustering to identify distinct organizational profiles. I show that sustainable funds are organizationally heterogeneous and that many are not structured to manage the tensions arising from their dual objectives. This architectural misalignment constrains their social impact potential, yet remains largely invisible to prevailing market frameworks, including SFDR and impact standards.

Publications & Conferences

Denis, **L.**, & Mottis, N. (2025). Responsible investors, minority but influential shareholders? The case of shareholder engagement with TotalEnergies SE. *Revue Française de Gestion*.

Mottis, N., & **Denis**, **L.** (2023). Shareholder engagement : the new frontier of sustainable finance ? *Bankers, Markets & Investors*.

Conferences:

- **2026**: European Academy of Management 2026, Academy of Management 2026 (STR Division)*, NBER Climate Finance 2026*, Impact Investing Days 2026*
- **2025**: European Group on Organization Studies 2025 (Greece), Alliance for Research on Corporate Sustainability 2025 (HEC Paris, France), East Coast Doctoral Conference 2025 (NYU, USA), Impact Investing Days 2025 (Audencia, France)
- **2024**: European Academy of Management 2024 (Bath, UK), European Group on Organization Studies 2024 (Milan, Italy)
- **2022 & 2023:** International Corporate Governance Society 2023 (IE Business School, Madrid, Spain), European Institute for Advanced Studies in Management - Corporate Governance 2022 (Strasbourg, France), i3 PhD Conference 2022 (Paris, France)
- **Seminars:** Columbia University PhD Seminar (2024, 2026), Columbia Business School PhD Seminar (2024), École Polytechnique (2023, 2024, 2025)
- **Invited Talks:** Time to Change 2025 (Annual Meetings of the French Association of Institutional Investors, France), France Invest (French Association of PE Firms) & FIR (French Sustainable Investment Forum) - Research Breakfast (June 2026), Entretiens de la Finance Durable (French Association of Institutional Investors, 2026)*
- **Summer Schools:** CEFAG 2024, XVII MEDICI SUMMER SCHOOL IN MANAGEMENT STUDIES (Bologna Business School, HEC Paris, MIT Sloan)

* Scheduled.

Teaching

- **Lecturer - Course Leader** at École Polytechnique (France) 2026
  Sustainability & Organizations (undergraduate)
- **Lecturer - Course Leader** at ENS Paris-Saclay (France) 2024–2026
  Introduction to Strategy & Corporate Governance (undergraduate)
- **Oral Examiner ("Khôlleur")** at CPGE ECT Notre-Dame de Grandchamp (France) 2021
  Accounting & Finance (undergraduate)

Scholarships, Grants and Awards

- Academy of Management STR Division - Outstanding Reviewer 2025, 2026
- Chaire Technology for Change (École Polytechnique) - 4th Year Funding 2025-2026
- French Sustainable Investment Forum & UN-PRI Awards - PhD Research Grant 2024-2026
- LABEX Louis Bachelier - Mobility Grant 2024
- Columbia University & École Polytechnique Alliance Program - Doctoral Mobility Grant 2024
- French Institutional Investors Association (Af2i) - Young Scholar Award 2024
- French Foundation for Management Science - CEFAG Doctoral Program & Grant 2024
- National Association for Research & Technology - CIFRE PhD Scholarship 2022–2025
- French Ministry of Research - Elève Normalien Scholarship 2018–2022

Work Experience

Trocadero Capital Partners — Paris, France
CIFRE PhD Student –PE Analyst — 2022–2024

- Developed a climate-focused impact investment strategy: reviewed existing impact and climate investing frameworks, participated to the development of the impact methodology and incentive scheme of the fund, supported the fundraising & structuring process
- Worked part-time as an Investment Analyst until March 2024: analyzed +60 investment opportunities (business model, business plan, financials, strategy, ESG & Impact), drafted 5 investment memos and participated to 4 investment committees

Centre de Recherche en Gestion - i^3, CNRS, École Polytechnique — Paris, France
Pre-Doctoral Research Assistant, Supervisor: Pr. Nicolas Mottis — 2021–2022

Cathay Capital — Paris, France
Private Equity Analyst (Internship) — 2021

Croix-Rouge française — Montrouge, France
Internal Auditor (Internship) — 2019

Skills & Languages

- Qualitative & quantitative research methodologies
- Corporate Finance, Private Equity, Financial Modeling
- Software: Python, R, SQL, VBA, Office, LaTeX

Languages

- French: native
- English: fluent

Other activities

- MIE Department, École Polytechnique — 2024
  PhD Student Representative
- Organisation CRG — 2024
  Organized research seminars & events with Pr. Etienne Minvielle

References

- **Pr. Nicolas Mottis** (nicolas.mottis@polytechnique.edu)
  Department of Management, Innovation & Entrepreneurship, École Polytechnique
- **Pr. Caroline Flammer** (caroline.flammer@columbia.edu)
  School of International & Public Affairs, Columbia University
- **Pr. Etienne Minvielle** (etienne.minvielle@polytechnique.edu)
  Center for Management Research, École Polytechnique
- **Alexandre Gazaniol** (alexandre.gazaniol@bpifrance.fr)
  Head of Impact Evaluation, Bpifrance